

How High Achievers Learn That They Should Not Become Teachers

ZID MANCENIDO

Harvard Graduate School of Education

In this article, Zid Mancenido examines how high-achieving students are socialized to believe that they should not become K–12 classroom teachers. Research has well established that academically successful students are often disinterested in teaching as a career, yet there has been little attention to how this disinterest is developed through the process of career exploration. To address this gap in the literature, Mancenido conducts a narrative inquiry based on interviews with high-achieving recent college graduates and graduating seniors. He presents six representative vignettes to demonstrate how high achievers learn through explicit and implicit signals that teaching is not appropriate for someone like them. This process is social, with parents and peers playing a significant role in shaping beliefs. These findings suggest that policy efforts to recruit more high achievers into teaching may benefit from more focus earlier in the career exploration pipeline.

Keywords: career exploration, elite colleges, narrative inquiry, teacher recruitment

“Feeling like you’ll graduate [elite university] and you’re not, I guess, fulfilling it . . . is still difficult for me, to be completely honest. [After learning more about teaching] I was so excited, and I am so excited, but it also actually scared me a bit. It’s like, what if this is where I’m at? What if I’m a teacher forever? That shouldn’t be a bad thing, I’m aware of that, but low-income Rory is thinking . . . that’s going to be difficult.”

As Rory tells me this over the phone, I’m walking slowly through a quadrangle enclosed by centuries-old buildings made of ivy-covered red-brick walls.¹ As I amble I think more about Rory’s words than my next steps. Students just like Rory pass by me, undergraduates shuffling from their dormitories to various classes and libraries. There is excitement mixed with anxiety in the air, the general feeling of a fast-approaching end of spring semester. I know Rory is in a similar quadrangle a few hundred miles away, a quadrangle also lined by ivy-covered red-brick student dormitories and also filled with tourists hoping to learn the secrets of one of the world’s most selective undergraduate institutions.

"Where do you think it comes from, this feeling that becoming a teacher isn't enough?" I ask.

Rory sighs. "A lot of places. Last week was the graduating seniors' dinner for [an extracurricular club]. We were all getting drinks and another senior was like, 'You're doing [the teacher preparation program]? You're just going to be a teacher?' She just ended it there, and I felt like I needed to say that 'No, I'll be a principal, I'll be a superintendent, I'll rise above blah blah blah.' But it's like, no, you're right. I'm going to just be a teacher. It shouldn't be like that, but it is what it is. It's something I'm still wrestling with.

This article is about how academically high-achieving college students like Rory (those who achieve high academic grades, standardized test scores, and GPAs) are socialized to think and feel like they should not become classroom teachers.² It is about how high achievers, particularly those who attend top-ranked national universities and elite liberal arts colleges, learn to believe that teaching is not an appropriate career choice, that choosing to be a teacher would be "settling," that it would be "beneath" them, that it is a "waste of potential." Negative conceptions of teaching among high achievers in the US have been widely touted in education research and policy making over the past few decades, something exemplified by common adages like "those who can't do, teach" and "teaching is a back-up option" (Darling-Hammond, 1984; Holmes Group, 1986; Labaree, 2004). For example, in his sociological study of teachers in the 1970s, Lortie (1975) described teaching as a "safety net," where "people who cannot make it as doctors, business executives, or professors can avoid slipping into work of considerably less social standing" (p. 50). Multiple nationally representative surveys attest to these negative conceptions. For example, the US General Social Survey reports public perception of the occupational prestige of teaching as relatively low in comparison to other professions requiring a college degree (Smith, Davern, Freese, & Morgan, 2019), and a 2014 national poll of high-achieving undergraduates "rated education as the top profession that 'average' people go into" (Hiler & Erickson, 2014).

Poor negative conceptions of teaching among high achievers are worthy of investigation for both normative and policy reasons. From a normative perspective, given the importance of education in society, it is important to understand how and why there is such negative public discourse about the teaching profession, including what it means for a society to cultivate beliefs that discourage those it perceives as its best and brightest from aspiring and choosing to teach. From a policy perspective, recent research has shown that incoming teachers' academic achievement is modestly related to their future students' academic achievement (D'Agostino & Powers, 2009; Hanushek, Piopiunik, & Wiederhold, 2019; Henry, Bastian, & Smith, 2012). While there remains ongoing discussion regarding what constitutes "teacher effectiveness" (Fenstermacher & Richardson, 2005), to the extent that one of the goals of schooling is students' academic achievement, these findings suggest there is

benefit for education systems in trying to attract more academic high achievers into the teaching profession.

Despite poor conceptions of teaching being a well-known and long-standing challenge for education policy makers, there has been surprisingly little attention to how they are *socially constructed*. Where does the idea that it is not right for high achievers to become teachers come from? When do high achievers first learn about it? How does it manifest? How is it perpetrated? In what contexts? Research has generally side-stepped these micro-level questions, focusing more on the macro level, on how certain social and material conditions of teaching lead to poor perceptions. For example, many researchers have discussed why teaching is not perceived as a highly skilled or prestigious profession. Reasons include: teachers are not experts in their disciplinary fields; teaching involves giving away one's expertise so that students no longer need them; the concept of good teaching is contested given the diverse ways individuals prefer to learn; teachers' impact on their students is hard to isolate, particularly because it is contingent on students' cooperation; teachers are caught "in between" the worlds of children and adults, leading many to perceive their work as lower status; and one's "apprenticeship of observation" across thirteen years of schooling generally leads individuals to underestimate the work of teaching (Cohen, 2011; Etzioni, 1969; Hoyle, 2001; Kennedy, 2006; Labaree, 2004; Lortie, 1975). As Rory intimated, the effects of these social conditions on perceptions of teaching are mutually reinforced by the profession's poor material conditions—its poor pay and working conditions (relative to other professions), etc. (Auguste, Kihn, & Miller, 2010; Barber & Mourshed, 2007; Farkas, Johnson, & Foleno, 2000; Rowsey & Ley, 1986; Sutchter, Darling-Hammond, & Carver-Thomas, 2016). There is no doubt that these social and material conditions are at the root of negative conceptions of teaching among high achievers. However, acknowledging this at the macro level gives little insight into how conceptions are developed at the micro level. For example, how do high achievers learn about these poor social and material conditions of teaching? How do they develop negative conceptions about teaching? From where and/or whom do they learn they should not become teachers?

Emerging sociological research into how students are socialized in elite institutions offers some suggestive answers. This research identifies young high achievers as committed yet highly impressionable career explorers (Binder, Davis, & Bloom, 2016; Schneider & Stevenson, 1999), using cues from their learning environments to construct an understanding of what are "socially appropriate" (read: "prestigious") career paths. While some of these cues are explicit (e.g., family and friends encouraging high achievers to pursue certain careers), most are implicit (e.g., who gets reified at college through alumni spotlights, public events, and major awards; the availability of information about certain careers on campus, including which firms and industries are present and prominent at events organized by career services). Together these

cues lead to a sort of “career funneling” whereby high achievers are streamed toward a narrow set of conventional pathways like law, medicine, technology, and financial services (Binder et al., 2016; Ho, 2009; Rivera, 2015).

In this article I look at these social processes within the specific case of teaching. I do this not just out of conceptual interest but also because of the policy implications of attracting more high achievers into the teaching profession. We know that poor conceptions of teaching contribute to why high achievers choose not to become teachers (Auguste et al., 2010; Farkas et al., 2000), but until we can identify the sites, experiences, and interactions that create and maintain these conceptions, we will continue to struggle to identify concrete actions that may disrupt them (Lawrence, Suddaby, & Leca, 2011; Battilana, Leca, & Boxenbaum, 2009). This is borne out in contemporary policy discussions. When discussing the negative perceptions of the teaching profession, many US policy makers tout policy platitudes (e.g., “we need to raise the status of the teaching profession”; “increase public respect for teachers”) and/or simply recommend that we first need to improve teachers’ material conditions like pay (e.g., Duncan, 2011; Satcher et al., 2016; Weingarten, 2019). To step beyond and develop more specific and targeted interventions that can subvert negative conceptions of teaching, we first need to understand how these conceptions are actually developed and fostered. We need to understand how high achievers learn that they should not become teachers.

To do this, I conduct a narrative inquiry using interview data from a broader research project on the career exploration and decision-making processes of ninety-six high-achieving recent college graduates and graduating seniors with varying levels of interest in and commitment to teaching. Drawing on key tenets of the methodology of portraiture (Lawrence-Lightfoot & Davis, 1997), I present six vignettes representative of the broader sample’s experiences. Read together, these vignettes reveal how high achievers initially learn and then have continuously reinforced negative conceptions of teaching. High achievers learn negative conceptions explicitly from family and friends who question and reroute any interest in teaching. They learn them implicitly from peers and mentors who deprioritize and eschew teaching as a long-term career. And they learn them consistently throughout their lives as they navigate others’ expectations that they pursue more prestigious career paths.

These vignettes are not meant to exhaustively sketch how high achievers learn about teaching as a career. Nor is their aim to causally link negative conceptions of teaching to high achievers’ unwillingness to become teachers or to discuss whether or justify why the teaching profession needs more high achievers. Rather, in this article, I simply highlight and elevate various ways high achievers learn about and grapple with negative conceptions of teaching. My hope is that educational researchers use this work to extend existing conceptual models for why high achievers may choose not to become teachers and that policy makers use this work to learn more deeply about the struggles, aspirations, and preoccupations of the target demographic that they seek to

recruit into the teaching profession. I also hope that educators and prospective teachers who read these vignettes feel seen in the experiences of my participants, that through these vignettes they are given a voice and a vocabulary to express feelings of uncertainty and confusion that can often characterize career exploration and decision making.

Method

The goal of this study is to provide an empirical grounding for the development of theory (Glaser & Strauss, 1967) regarding when, where, and how high achievers are socialized to become disinterested in teaching. Given the challenge of needing to both capture the idiosyncrasy of an individual's process of socialization and draw generalizations from across diverse experiences, I conduct a narrative inquiry that draws on key tenets from portraiture, a qualitative social science methodology that "seeks to document and illuminate the complexity and detail of a unique experience or place" in order to "discover resonant universal themes" (Lawrence-Lightfoot & Davis, 1997, p. 14). Key to theory building through portraiture is *identification*, the use of aesthetic features like voice and storytelling to evoke "the energizing shock of sympathy and of human community" (Featherstone, 1989, p. 376). In this way, the aim of portraiture is to "make companionable for you a person who is identified or unknown" (Schjeldahl, 2019) so that "the familiar scene outside, the road and the bustle, often look transformed and transfigured" (Gombrich, 1969, cited in Lawrence-Lightfoot & Davis, 1997, p. 35).

Another key tenet of portraiture is its commitment toward *goodness*, a commitment that eschews conceptual negativism in the hope of drawing novel insights about its focal phenomenon. As Lawrence-Lightfoot and Davis (1997) write, "The researcher who asks first 'what is good here?' is likely to absorb a very different reality than the one who is on a mission to discover the sources of failure" (p. 9). When I began this project, many colleagues told me that although there were some exceptions, most high achievers would never choose the teaching profession because teachers are too poorly paid and not respected. Their concerns echoed what I heard in public discourse and read in the existing research literature—highlighting sources of failure in the teaching profession (e.g., poor pay, poor prestige) and then arguing that many will not choose to teach until these deficits are addressed. While I did not disagree that these were challenging issues, what was missing from these portrayals of high achievers was the depth and texture of my own and my students' experiences of wrestling with, actively considering, and, in some cases, loving their decision to choose to teach. I felt like public portrayals of why many choose not to teach were too flat, too quick to assume that high achievers consider only the poor pay or poor prestige. These portrayals rarely reflected on or considered the broader social and structural factors that divert any possibility of interest or foster disinterest in teaching. In other words, I began this

project inspired by portraiture's commitment to seeing the goodness, humanity, and complexity in high achievers' career exploration and decision-making processes. This contrasts with research that primarily starts from deficit-based assumptions about teaching and treats high achievers as overly deterministic and narrowly focused on these negative aspects.

The greatest challenge in embarking on this project was defining the study population and sample—What does it mean to be an “academic high achiever”? How do we decide who is and who isn't? High school GPA or standardized test scores? How do I sample participants with these characteristics? These were difficult questions to answer, not least because conventional markers of academic achievement like test scores and college admissions underrepresent the achievement of many demographic groups, given that the opportunity to succeed in our education system is partially dictated by race, class, gender, sexuality, nationality, etc. That said, to undertake this study I needed to make a choice. As such, I chose to focus on high achievers who attend elite undergraduate institutions and top-ranked, highly selective teacher preparation programs. I did this because attending an elite institution is one of the most prominent and most public markers of achievement in the US. After all, it is quite common for high achievers to be defined by the college and universities they attend(ed) (e.g., “DeMarcus is so smart. He went to Yale”). There are many limitations to this focus, however, including the fact that given how few people attend top-ranked colleges and universities in the US and how opaquely selective they are, most high achievers are unlikely to attend such institutions (Karabel, 2005; Warikoo, 2016). That said, choosing this focus allows me to engage with how achievement is commonly defined in public discourse. This is critical given the aim of this study is to better understand how perceptions of teaching among high achievers is socially constructed.

I recruited ninety-six recent college graduates and/or graduating seniors through the academic and residential mailing lists of four elite college campuses and the interested/admitted students mailing lists of four highly selective teacher preparation programs. I used a maximum variation approach (Patton, 1990) to collect and represent the many ways high achievers learn about teaching. To do this, I conducted interviews over a number of months. Rather than just interviewing anyone who initially expressed interest, I purposefully selected participants to ensure a diverse sample based on demographic indicators; on applying, interested participants had provided their demographic information, including gender, race/ethnicity, and undergraduate major, as well as information about whether they had ever been interested in teaching as a career. I also recruited across two distinct time periods, May–July of 2018 ($n=41$) and May–July of 2020 ($n=55$), to allow me to recruit across multiple campuses and programs and to enable me to check the robustness of my findings across time. This recruitment procedure led to a final sample of participants, with 35.4 percent who identified as male, 58.3 percent as nonwhite, and 50 percent as majoring in STEM fields, and with an average SAT score of 2211

(above the ninety-eighth percentile). This is not representative of the broader US teacher labor force, where approximately 23 percent of teachers are male and 20 percent are nonwhite (Goldring, Taie, & Riddles, 2014) and there is a well-acknowledged shortage of qualified STEM teachers (Cowan, Goldhaber, Hayes, & Theobald, 2016).

While I made an effort to recruit participants from a range of colleges, it is important to acknowledge that 89.5 percent of study participants graduated from a college ranked in *U.S. News & World Report's* "Top 20 National Universities" or "Top 20 Liberal Arts Colleges" in 2019. This recruitment procedure, therefore, does not allow me to make generalizations about the broader population of high achievers in the US; after all, there are many high achievers attending less selective institutions, such as large regional public universities. That said, I chose this recruitment process because my purpose was not to describe more generally the experience of high achievers in the US but, rather, to investigate more closely why and how high achievers are socialized to hold negative perceptions of teaching. Research has shown that negative perceptions of public service careers like teaching are most prevalent in elite educational contexts (Binder et al., 2016). Thus, by recruiting participants primarily from elite institutions, I was able to ensure that I was selecting those who may have experienced the sort of socialization that was the focus of the study. In addition, I restrict the focus of this article to identifying and highlighting unifying themes across participants rather than drawing out differences across participants' elite institutional contexts. Other research has already investigated institutional differences. For example, Reback (2006) finds that high achievers attending highly selective institutions that do not offer teacher education pathways are less likely to become teachers than high achievers attending highly selective institutions that do. Thus, I look to future research to utilize a more wide-ranging recruitment procedure to understand the "average" high-achiever experience and how such experiences may vary across the diverse range of educational contexts in the US.

Each of the semi-structured interviews lasted between fifty and seventy-five minutes and were conducted in person, via online video conferencing or by phone. In interviewing participants, I adopted a narrative inquiry approach (Carter, 1993; Kelchtermans & Vandenberghe, 1994; Tripp, 1994), in which participants are asked to recall significant events and individuals in their lives to make explicit the influences on their present choices and actions. For this study, I gave individuals a single prompt: "Tell us the story of how you came to be doing what you are doing now career wise. Where you start is completely up to you, as long as you can help us understand how your career interests started and how they have developed over time." I asked follow-up questions, diving into various themes, including college experiences, such as academics, extracurricular activities, and internships; influences from parents, mentors, and peers; and campus recruitment events and culture. If the participant did not mention teaching during the interview, I asked a final set of questions prob-

ing into any experiences and conversations they may have had where teaching as a career was brought up. I purposely structured interviews in this open-ended way to ensure that I did not bias participants' recollections by indicating hypotheses through specific questions. Interviews were audio-recorded and then transcribed verbatim.

Critical to the narrative inquiry approach is participant openness and honesty. Since I did not know any participants before interviewing them, I needed to quickly develop trusting relationships so they would be willing to share quite personal life stories with me, stories some participants may not have even shared with close family and friends. To do this, I began interviews by showing vulnerability and modeling an openness and honesty that I hoped they could reach with me by the end of the interview. I began by sharing my own experiences of my career exploration, including experiencing explicit and implicit signals toward certain prestigious careers and away from public service careers. I also shared my experiences as an undergraduate advisor at an elite institution, telling them about my motivation for undertaking this study after witnessing students' struggles navigating others' and their own expectations when making career decisions. By exposing myself in this way at the outset, I created emotional space for participants to dive deep into their own stories. While it is difficult to present data on the effectiveness of this approach, many participants remarked at the conclusion of their interview that it was a "reflective experience" and/or "cathartic" and enabled them to think about things that they had not thought deeply about before.

I analyzed interview data in two stages. First, I listened and relistened to my participants' life histories, coding the influences on their career exploration and decision-making. I developed the codes while listening to the interviews; as I listened to one, then another, I reflected on whether any particular influences conformed to or diverged from any previously identified code. Second, after carefully listing and analyzing these codes, I selected six participant experiences that seemed representative of the broader sample, which I present here as vignettes (Rory's story, which opens the article, is the first vignette; the other five follow below). In selecting these six, I balanced the range and frequency of codes across the sample. For example, family and peer influences were often reported across the sample and therefore are presented across multiple vignettes. Conversely, the influence of university administrators was reported only a handful of times and so appears in only one vignette.

In what follows, I present each vignette individually, and then, in the final section, I draw out common themes and identify further questions. I purposefully reserve analysis and synthesis of the vignettes until this final section to preserve the independence of each of the vignettes. This is important given that I conducted the interviews individually and across different times and contexts. In analyzing and presenting my data in this way, I undertake what others have described as "puzzle building" (Preissle & LeCompte, 1984; Lawrence-Lightfoot & Davis, 1997): first, I steadily and systematically analyze the data to

draw out the “pieces” from my participants’ life histories, and then I deliberately and iteratively put together those pieces to reveal the broader “puzzle.” I quote my participants extensively to preserve as much as possible their distinct voices and the sentiments beneath them. In doing this, I see my role as a curator: finding ways to put together the various pieces to amplify their messages for the reader. As Lawrence-Lightfoot and Davis (1997) describe it, “The actors sing the solo lines, the portraitist supporting their efforts at articulation, insight, and expressiveness” (p. 85).

Admittedly, in collecting, analyzing, and presenting data in this way, I may have overinterpreted similarities across participants, seeing patterns where there are none by unintentionally obscuring small but meaningful differences (Miles & Huberman, 1994). This may be a particular concern given my aim of trying to identify and highlight “representative” portraits and given my own educational background and career path—I attended an honors college within a large public university, and I wrestled with but ultimately chose to become a teacher directly following graduation. This personal history could lead me to reify themes that most resonate with my experience, even though they are not the most common themes among my participants. To guard against this, first, as is a key tenet of portraiture, I sought out the “deviant voices” in my data to construct “a view that resists caricature” (Lawrence-Lightfoot, 2000). I present some of these voices that seem not to fit the dominant conception, recognizing that “the contrasting image does not detract from the conception, but actually underscores its centrality and power” (Lawrence-Lightfoot & Davis, 1997, p. 248). And second, to ensure that I remained grounded in the broader motivation and context of the study, I collaborated with other researchers who had an understanding of the research literature and the context of elite colleges but who did not participate in my data collection and analysis process. With them I discussed emerging themes, and I asked them to challenge me for evidence on themes that seemed conceptually muddy or empirically unsupported.

Results

Ashley: “It’s subtle”

It’s only been two weeks since Ashley finished her Peace Corps assignment teaching English to elementary school students in Nicaragua. It’s also only been thirty minutes since she finished teaching a history lesson to grade 10 summer school students at the local high school. And yet when we sit down to talk in the lobby of her top-ranked graduate school of education, Ashley looks me straight in the eyes with a presentness and warmth that belies any sense that her life over the past month has been a whirlwind. She has just started her one-year Master’s in Teaching program; the summer school class is her first practicum.

"How are you adjusting to being back from Nicaragua?" I ask.

"I love it," she beams. "It's so good to be here. I might crash eventually, but right now I'm running on adrenaline . . . I love working with kids, I've always loved it. I've always felt so in my element in a classroom."

While I ordinarily relegate such platitudes to things one says in a job interview, Ashley's tone is kind and rings with an authenticity that is disarming, almost intimidating. I ask her whether she's always been so sure of this, whether she's always felt this positively about teaching.

"No, definitely not. That's why I did the Peace Corps. That's why I didn't major in education." Ashley shrugs. "In my undergrad, I was an International Studies major. I was interested in teaching, but there was just a certain type of person that did the education program, and I didn't really necessarily feel like I was that type of person . . . This was reinforced by my academic advisor. I just brought up in one of our meetings junior year that I had been volunteering in schools and thinking about doing education, and he was kind of like, 'Ditch that. You have really high academic scores. You could be a lawyer, you can be a diplomat. Why would you want to go into teaching?'"

On the wall above Ashley is a framed blackboard, on it the phrase "every child, every classroom, every day" is written in cursive in chalk. It's just one of the many positive messages about education and the value of teaching that adorn the walls on this campus. Ashley notices and follows my gaze. The irony isn't lost on her. "Don't get me wrong," she says. "I really enjoyed my college experience, but there was this moment where I feel like if people had encouraged me to go into education instead, I could have been tipped in that direction."

"What encouragement did you get instead?"

Ashley pauses for a moment, then starts slowly. "I feel . . . as I got older . . . people in my life and in my community . . . if I pitched the idea of teaching they would respond one way—not in a negative way, but they would respond maybe in a neutral way. But then when I pitched the idea of maybe wanting to go to the State Department or be a lawyer, their response was really enthusiastic."

I ask whether this was a feeling she got across the board or from only specific people, like her advisor.

"Not everyone but some people," she says. "I don't know. It was really subtle, but I just remember a couple conversations with professors and extended family members where I got that distinct—If I said one thing, the reaction would be like, 'Oh, okay' or like, 'Teachers work so hard, but it's such an important job' . . . Instead of like, 'Wow, that's awesome. You'd be so great at that' and 'Oh, that's such a glamorous job. That would be such an exciting job to have,' which is the response I got when I mentioned I might be interested in the State Department or Peace Corps and stuff like that."

I wonder how persistent this discourse has been. I ask, "Do people still say this stuff to you now?"

Ashley smiles. “Some people are a little bit surprised now when I tell them I’ve shifted away from International Studies and back toward doing education. No one is negative about it. Some people are surprised though.”

“Can I ask how that surprise manifests?”

“Yeah . . . Just like in conversations mostly with old friends and mentors from college, people who I didn’t talk to much while in Nicaragua . . . Like when I said, ‘I’m applying to these Master’s in Teaching programs,’ and then they’re like, ‘Oh, but I thought you were thinking about going into the foreign service or like doing law school or something like that.’ It’s kind of just a question, but it’s subtle, you know, the surprise that I ended up choosing to do teaching.”

Micah: “The teachers were always struggling”

It’s 9:30 p.m. on a Tuesday halfway through the spring semester. Micah sits opposite me on a large dark-brown leather sofa, his backpack and jacket strewn on the floor beside him. We’re meeting late because it’s the only time he can make given the hours he spends in the engineering lab. We are sitting in a student common room that looks like a stereotype of an elite college’s student common room. Dark-wood bookshelves line the walls. A shield bearing house symbols and insignia hangs above a fireplace. Purple velvet curtains, pulled aside by cords with tassels, frame the floor-to-ceiling windows. A grand piano sits in the corner.

At 6’2” and well built, with a perfectly shaped fade, Micah looks exactly like he is: a star Texas high school football player. We’ve already discussed how he was recruited to play football at college; how he played one year and then decided it wasn’t for him, preferring other extracurriculars like mentoring in schools and singing in an acapella group. We’ve also talked about how he ended up studying engineering—“It was a fluke.” In his first year at college, a friend told him he’d like the class. He went, he liked it, and he’s been taking classes ever since. I ask if he had other career plans before arriving at college, whether people around him had suggested he should study something in particular.

Micah tells me, “A lot of people associate [elite college] with the law school. That’s the impression that comes to mind, so everybody used to think that I was going there to get a degree in law . . . People always just thought I was going to be a lawyer. People would say things like ‘You could be a future president,’ stuff like that. Nobody ever really said anything else or made any other assumptions.”

I ask him about his family of teachers, wondering whether they held the same expectations.

“I think it was beneficial for me, having a mother, grandmother, and aunt in teaching.” Micah sits contemplatively, leaning forward with his elbows on his knees, his hands pressed lightly together near his face. His posture matches his thought process; his speech is even-keeled. “It helped me establish and

respect my teachers for one, and it also helped me with what I was learning. But I also saw the kinds of struggle they had working with kids every day, some of the stresses they had from having to work for different administrators, or from working to get students ready for tests because that's like the big push nowadays. I guess I saw both the rewarding aspects of it and also some of the things that were less rewarding."

"Did you talk about teaching with your mother, grandmother, or aunt while you were trying to figure out what to do for a career?"

"Yeah," he responds quickly. "They really didn't have any direct advice. It was just, 'Do what you think is best because you're the one who has to live with that decision.'"

I follow up, "But did hearing from them about how difficult teaching was make you stray away from considering it?"

He demurs. "Maybe. My aunt and I, we talk every day and share what we're both going through. And, you know, sometimes the bad outweighs the good, and when we talk she mentions how bad the kids were that day, how disrespectful they were, the things that they have done, so on, and so forth."

I venture a hypothesis that these conversations with his family stimulated a disinterest in teaching as a career. Micah counters, "I think it was mostly experiencing it in schools myself." He starts telling me stories about volunteering in schools as a teaching assistant. "I was only there an hour a week, so you don't get a great picture of what it'd be like to be a teacher full time . . . but I feel like it was very disrespectful for the teacher, even with someone else like me present, the kids didn't want to act appropriately. Just the way students were acting, the things they would say . . . The teachers were always struggling to get them to listen and to actually be interested in learning. And it wasn't all the students . . . You just have a couple in the class who act that way, and then it kind of takes away from the entire class."

I press him to explain further, openly wondering whether he's just extrapolating from a couple of bad experiences, whether if he was in a different classroom with different students and a different teacher, everything might have turned out a little differently.

Micah shrugs. "I wouldn't say that I have a whole understanding of what being a teacher is like, but I've heard at home what my mother and aunt go through, and I've volunteered in schools a bit . . . and together it just gave me a snapshot of what it would be like to be a teacher and how difficult it would be."

Ife: "Something that you do in between"

"I was very young, very, very young . . . There's a picture of me in my dad's doctor's office probably in junior kindergarten." Ife laughs. She is responding to my question about when she knew that her family expected her to become a doctor. Ife and I both know that it isn't an expectation that she's ever resisted. As we've talked, she's regaled me with stories of childhood, of

her doctor father and nurse practitioner mother, of a high school summer spent at a neuropsychology program that cultivated an intellectual curiosity, of a series of inspirational science and math teachers who challenged her and made her feel at home in the sciences, of a community of pre-med college students with whom she has dissected and discussed a career in the life sciences. Ife punctuates these stories with sidebars and laughter; she is self-deprecating and self-aware.

I ask Ife about whether there has ever been the possibility of any other career than medicine. Throughout our conversation, Ife has indicated an interest in education, but this time she says outright she once looked into Teach for America and at her college's fifth-year teaching program as something to do "in between" college and medical school. "When I say I'm obsessed with school, it's half a joke," she says, "but I'm actually serious . . . I've just always really cared about how things are taught. When I got to college, I would just roast classes when I thought they weren't taught to standard. It would just be in so many of my conversations with my family and friends."

"So have you ever discussed with your parents about being a teacher?"

Ife laughs. "I don't know if we explicitly talked about being like a *teacher* teacher, but . . . we definitely talk about me being in academia. So if I told [my father] I was thinking about being a teacher, he would think I'm talking about being a college professor . . . He would be very comfortable about that because LOL you're still going to medical school to teach something." As Ife talks, she traces the deeply ingrained expectation of her attending medical school and becoming a doctor. "But I think my mom—it's very much in my family's persona that I love school, so doing something like teaching wouldn't be too out there. There would definitely be side-eye, but my mom would probably eventually be very accepting of it, especially because in her mind it would be 'This will still lead to medical school!' . . . In her mind, teaching would just be something that I'd be doing 'in between' college and medical school."

I ask where this idea of teaching as "in between" comes from. Ife wavers a little. "I think it's just what's more common for people here." She mentions a friend's partner who completed her elite college's fifth-year teacher certification program, taught for three years, and then went to law school. She notes that a college advisor connected her with a medical resident, also an alumnus, who taught for three years before medical school. Both spoke glowingly of their time in teaching, emphasizing how well it prepared them for their future careers. As Ife tells me about these alumni, I note how despite these glowing reviews, despite the social encouragement, she still does not sound convinced about teaching. I wonder what it would have taken and ask her directly.

Ife laughs. "My dad nearly cried when I told him I thought about becoming a lawyer. I took a constitutional law class in freshman year and was like, 'This is interesting' . . . Yeah, that was a tough conversation." She nods and smiles. She knows it's funny but also that it's not a joke. "The most side-eye I would get if I chose to become a teacher would be from my parents. But generally from

[students at elite university] overall, they're either just neutral—"Ok, cool. You want to do it, that's great"—but no one is wildly excited by it. I think no one is steering me away from it, but no one is like, 'Oh my gosh! You should definitely do this!' It's just something that you do in between."

Graham: "I need to be more strategic"

It's been a month since graduation, and in a month Graham starts at a well-known management consulting firm in New York City. He's back home in California, renting a beach house with friends to pass the summer. He tells me that the house is only fifteen or so miles from the high-performing urban charter high school he attended but then says that given the friends he is on holiday with, the cultural references they make, and how much they are spending on recreational activities, the beach house is much more a reflection of the elite college he attended nearly three thousand miles away in the Northeast.

Graham is articulate and matter of fact, the sort of college student you talk to and get the impression they have it all figured out. He tells me he started college thinking he was interested in education: "I didn't know exactly where I wanted to go, or exactly what type of teaching or education that I wanted to do. I'd heard things like going to get a PhD and getting a professorship might be one way to approach it." He says that in high school he was never told that doing a teacher preparation program was an option—"Everyone was just focused on getting me into a good college."

When I ask, Graham notes that his interest in education came from seeing the disparity between his urban charter school and other schools. His mother was a teacher, and early on she encouraged him to see and investigate all the educational inequities around him. He wrote about this in his college application essay. He tells me, "I went through an incredible charter school in Los Angeles next to other charter schools that either lost their accreditation or otherwise sent less than 20 percent of people to college." When he got to college, he "took a few courses in education, did not get a minor or major or anything, and the teacher practicum at [elite college] was not considered particularly prestigious or robust and was generally thought of as a way to increase your GPA, or otherwise just not really respected as a program."

"Where did you get the sense that the education courses weren't that well respected?" I ask.

Graham looks at me and smiles, like the question is too obvious. As with any simple question about how we "know" about prevalent sociocultural norms, the answer is everywhere and nowhere at the same time. "Well for one, in freshman year a lot of other people wanted to do education, but by the time I made it to senior year, no one talked about it at all . . . And then, if I told someone that I was considering doing teaching, I might get a sympathetic look. I might get something like, 'That's so nice of you. I don't think I could ever do that. I'm not good with children. I can't be an implementer or a low-level

worker, I need to be more strategic.’ That, I think, was the most explicit that it got, that people just didn’t really respect the field of teaching.”

These are codes I have heard from others as well: teaching described as “technical” or “frontline,” simple codes used by some high achievers to distinguish teaching from their personal interests focusing on “broader,” “high-level,” “policy,” and/or “strategic” issues. I hear these codes as language games, delineations of occupational prestige and status masked otherwise as personal preferences.

“How else was it revealed that teaching was not respected?”

“Most of it was nonexplicit,” he says. “It wasn’t what people said but the ways they spent their time. Even though people said at the very beginning that they were very interested in education, they would take courses in economics or they would take courses in political science but not in education and not in teaching. Or when it came to career fairs, we would walk down the hallway, and the private-sector side would have lines of 10 to 20 people next to each booth and the nonprofit side would have 5 people walking across 20 different companies. It was just visual. People were voting with their feet. It was just eminently clear that the two were not treated the same.”

Graham is quick to admit that these early and consistent signals from peers were persuasive. Instead of education, he majored in mechanical engineering. He says, “Just being surrounded by peers who are not considering your option makes it very difficult to choose it . . . You’re defying what is okay and what is normal by the people and activities around you.”

Our conversation pauses, and over the phone I can hear the waves in the background. I am curious why Graham is so socially influenced. I know the president of Graham’s alma mater had recently spoken at his graduation about the importance of not necessarily following others, of doing what matters, of choosing paths that will have a tangible impact on the world.

I break the silence. “You went to [elite university]! Why are you so worried about what everyone thinks? You made it! You got in. Can’t you do whatever you want?”

Graham laughs. He can tell I’ve asked the question facetiously, but he answers it seriously. “It’s funny. Everyone thinks that we’ve got it, but we’re all still too insecure. I certainly was, and definitely still am.” Switching gears, he asks me how many people I know who are trained teachers but can’t get jobs. He says he doesn’t know many teachers other than his mother, but he does know—through college alumni networks and peer groups—a few management consultants from the firm he’s starting at in the fall. He says he knows no one who looks or sounds like they have had trouble getting jobs. At first I think this is a joke, but Graham pushes on. “There’s no reason to believe that the rest of your life is going to be easy after college, even after a place like [elite university]. Throughout college I applied for so many jobs that just never responded to me. I know so many friends who have graduated and have

not gotten jobs . . . Consulting has some of the best exit opportunities, same as finance. You've got to hedge your bets."

Emily: "It was so absolute"

"In a sense . . . hmm . . . I was actually pretty shocked by my mother's reaction, I guess . . . and like it actually made it so . . . we don't argue that often, but there was a lot of discontent, at the time . . . and then we talked about it later . . . but like I think she just felt the logistical impossibility—no not impossibility. It would just be significantly difficult to like pursue it."

We are toward the end of our interview, and Emily can't find the right words. She is trying to describe her mother's reaction during a "tiny hot second" she considered teaching while in college. Sitting on the floor of her childhood bedroom with her laptop angled against her legs, Emily shifts her posture and the webcam bounces. She apologizes and blames it on tiredness—she submitted her senior thesis quite late yesterday, a web application that uses machine learning to analyze sound bites, a merging of her two interests in linguistics and computer science. I tell her there's nothing to apologize about.

Our conversation has bounced around. Emily speaks quickly and in short utterances, not all fully connected. There are often long pauses. The sentences come together, but only after piecing together the fragments. She often asks, "Does that make sense?" and I take a moment to give us both time to think through all that she's said.

So far, Emily has described a range of interests that developed early in high school, such as language learning, robotics, dance, music. These interests progressively coalesced into her current interest, human computer interactions, which led to her postgraduation plans: software engineer at a large technology firm.

"What made you think about teaching in the first place?" I ask. With a father working in early childhood curriculum development and a mother teaching Mandarin, Emily tells me that she knew that teaching was a career, but she had never thought about it while growing up. Even when I ask explicitly, she says she can never remember anyone suggesting or even asking her about teaching: "While growing up did anyone ask you whether you had thought about becoming a teacher?" "No." "How about a doctor?" "Yes, loads."

But then Emily tells me about a conversation with her roommate in sophomore year.

"My roommate had just come back from the Education Career Fair and she had a bunch of pamphlets, and we were going through them, talking about them . . . We always talked about careers and stuff, whenever anyone came back home and was thinking about something or wanted to talk about some internship or job they found . . . Anyway, we were talking and she just said something along the lines of, 'I think you would be really great, and there are not enough people who teach STEM, so please do it!'"

While different from other high achievers' experiences like those described above, I am not surprised by Emily's roommate's emphatic support of teaching. I know that her elite college recently embarked on raising the visibility of public service careers like teaching, having recently approved an education studies minor and a fifth-year teacher certification program. Emily acknowledged this herself early on in our conversation, saying, "I remember at [orientation] the dean said something which I remember . . . people have this perspective that like you're either a doctor, lawyer, accountant, engineer, or a loser. There's really like nothing else you can be." I also attended that dean's orientation speech and remember the line. It was followed by an entreaty to reject social pressures that associate occupational prestige with meaning and impact. The lines were part of a broader hope that the incoming class would explore diverse career options, take academic and extracurricular risks, and not just follow the well-worn post-graduation paths of consulting, finance, medicine, and technology.

"And so when was the moment you brought up teaching with your parents?"

Emily *umms* and *ahhs*. She shifts her position and the camera bounces around again, moving her in and out of focus. "So a week after that, because my parents live nearby and . . . so we just eat and chill for a bit every week or so. I brought it up and—" As she speaks, Emily starts and stops multiple times, taking long pauses as she searches for the words to say. "It was not well received . . . Which is why it was, like, shocking because they don't frequently have that kind of reaction to things that I say . . . Most times they say things like 'keep exploring,' 'you have time to make up your mind.' This was the first time it was so absolute." Emily pauses.

"What do you mean by 'shocking'?" I ask. "What sorts of things was your mom saying?"

Emily's eyes flash with recognition. Suddenly, in stark contrast to the moment before, she responds quickly, in fragments, as if she's just remembered so much and yet can't accurately describe it. "She was like shocked in a negative way, mostly because she felt like she knew it would be extremely challenging, and especially having experienced, to some degree, teaching herself. She just especially given the environment I grew up in in suburban Massachusetts, it's not necessarily meant I've had, like, the experiences where I would be equipped to work in urban schools. Even if I would hope to be able to make an impact, I shouldn't do it for growth because it's not like what I've been prepared for, because like maybe there are others who are more or better prepared for it. She just . . . she just had a pretty negative reaction."

We sit in silence for a few beats. Then Emily nods. "Yeah, that was pretty much it."

I nod as well. I can tell that it wasn't so much exactly what Emily's mother had said but the speed and emphasis of the rejection that was impactful. Put into the broader context of supportive interactions encouraging her to

explore various career options, the swiftness and negativity must, indeed, have been shocking.

I follow up with, “And so you never really thought about teaching after that?”

“Yeah, I never did again.”

Discussion: What Can We Learn?

What do these vignettes tell us about how high achievers learn that they should not become teachers? First and foremost, Rory’s, Ashley’s, Micah’s, Ife’s, Graham’s, and Emily’s stories demonstrate how high achievers’ ideas about teaching and careers are *learned*. A naive model for why high achievers have negative conceptions of teaching as a career may run as follows: teachers are paid poorly and not respected; high achievers want careers that pay well and are well respected; therefore, high achievers do not want to become teachers. Read collectively, the stories add depth, breadth, and texture to this simple model. High achievers are not born knowing that teaching is not perceived as an appropriate career path for someone like them. Rather, they learn it and relearn it through signals built into their interactions with family and friends. They learn it through others’ expectations of them and their careers. They learn it through observing the career trajectories of their role models and their peers.

These stories also emphasize that while for some the signal to not pursue teaching is explicit (e.g., Ashley’s academic advisor and Emily’s parents), for most high achievers the signals are implicit; they learn through implication, observation, and by example. Ashley learned that teaching was not respected through observing her peers’ and mentors’ responses to her career interests. The notion that teaching was not respected was reinforced for Micah by listening to stories from his family members and observing students while volunteering in local schools. Through observing others who graduated from her university, Ife learned that teaching is just an “in between” job before moving on to something else like law or medical school. These stories emphasize that high achievers’ negative conceptions of teaching are fostered and reinforced primarily through what they see others *do* rather than just what they hear others *say*. As Graham remarked, “It wasn’t what people said but the ways they spent their time.”

Further, these vignettes highlight the particularly strong influences of parents in high achievers’ developing conceptions of teaching. Although the trope of “following in the family business” is very familiar in other sectors, it has been underexplored as it relates to the career exploration and decision-making process of prospective teachers. What makes this an interesting avenue for future inquiry is that the direction and magnitude of influences seem variable. For some, parental attitudes toward teaching can be negative (e.g., Emily’s shock in discovering her parents’ strong disapproval of her nascent

interest in teaching and Micah's admission that his family's challenging experiences as teachers framed how he came to perceiving teaching); for others, it can be positive (e.g., Graham's mother encouraging him to observe the educational inequity surrounding him).

These vignettes complicate the narrative for how high achievers develop negative conceptions of the teaching profession. Previous research has emphasized the influence of material conditions of teaching, such as poor pay, working conditions, and limited career opportunities. These vignettes suggest that most high achievers do not learn about these material conditions directly; rather, they learn about them through social interactions. Emily did not learn that teaching could be poorly paid from teacher salary agreements or employment contracts; she learned this through her mother's objections. Ife did not learn about the long-term career options of teachers through school system workforce planning documents; she learned about it by talking to others who chose to teach and then left to pursue other careers.

Finally, these stories expand the scope of what contributes to poor conceptions of the teaching profession. Ashley was told that she should not become a teacher because her grades were too high. Graham observed that the career opportunities for those interested in education were not deemed attractive enough by those at his college. Both Ashley and Graham were routed away from education studies programs at their respective college because they felt that others perceived it as not "rigorous" enough. These experiences suggest that we should think about how poor perceptions of teaching are not just caused by material conditions of already practicing teachers. We should also think about the influence of conditions like the prevalence and accessibility of socially sanctioned pathways to becoming a teacher for those who are considering teaching as a career.

So what do these lessons suggest for how we can disrupt negative conceptions of teaching among high achievers? They suggest that, like any other social institution, high achievers' negative conceptions of teaching are learned, and that they are learned in specific sites and in specific ways across the career exploration and decision-making process. It is beyond the scope of this article to conclude what must be done to disrupt all this learning. However, the findings indicate that there may be alternative policy levers that school systems could use to disrupt these narratives. These policy levers should be foci for future investigations.

To date, most policies aimed at recruiting high achievers into the teaching profession have primarily focused on offering financial incentives at career entry (e.g., scholarships, loan forgiveness, and/or alternative certification pathways). Research generally finds these policies to be effective (Henry et al., 2012), but only for those individuals already interested in teaching (Liu, Johnson, & Peske, 2004). In other words, for the vast majority of students, financial incentives at career entry come too late in the pipeline.

This research accords with the findings of this study, which indicate that negative conceptions of teaching are likely already well-developed by the time students are finishing college and considering postgraduation careers. This suggests that system-level policies aimed at recruiting more high achievers may have broader reach if they started earlier in the pipeline, targeting students during their career exploration in late high school and early college, and/or if they broadened their focus to include people who influence high achievers' career decision-making, such as family, friends, and mentors.

For example, given how much career exploration and decision-making happens on college campuses, school systems could partner with elite institutions to further raise the visibility and desirability of teaching. School system and college communications offices could collaborate to identify and raise the profile of alumni working as teachers, something that could explicitly address students' and parents' underlying conceptions of whether teaching is a socially legitimate pathway for an elite college graduate. School systems could provide incentives to high achievers at elite colleges to explore teaching, such as through term time or summer internships that count as course credit, or through service-learning courses that get college students working in K–12 schools. School systems could also reach out to professors to help them develop courses that engage with problems in K–12 schools and/or ask them to explicitly encourage high achievers to consider teaching as a career. Finally, systems could collaborate with college career services offices to help provide students with more information about a career in teaching rather than just the usual suspects like finance, law, and technology.

Given that the high achievers in my study mostly learned about teaching second- or third-hand, school systems could also develop and target structured opportunities for high achievers to learn directly about the promises and possibilities of a career in teaching. This could include developing outreach programs that target high achievers early, perhaps even in their final year of high school, getting them into classrooms, learning about teaching and its long-term prospects, and connecting them with other like-minded peers. While this may not directly address negative signals about teaching, it may help outweigh negative signals by providing high achievers with access to experiences and social interactions that make teaching more attractive.

More broadly, this study suggests the need to shift public discourse about teaching and whether it is an appropriate career path for high achievers. There is no simple policy solution to change public discourse, however, this study raises one issue that has been previously investigated by Reback (2006): elite colleges rarely offer teaching degrees, and high achievers who attend elite colleges without teaching as a degree option are less likely to become teachers. Although I did not set out to test or elaborate on Reback's work, my findings highlight the underlying normative issue: (a) given that high achievers seek to attend and generally gain entry to elite colleges, and (b) given that colleges are perceived as where one goes to prepare for their future career,

then therefore (c) teaching is not portrayed as an appropriate career for high achievers so long as elite institutions rarely offer teaching degrees. While the policy implications for addressing this are not obvious, it is a necessary area for future research since high achievers' college experiences strongly influence their career exploration and decision-making, and since elite colleges play an outsized role in public discourse about high achievers and appropriate career pathways.

In identifying these potential policy implications and possible areas for future research, it is important to note the limits of generalizability given that most study participants attended elite colleges (the six participants profiled attended three different highly selective elite universities and one moderately selective regional college). It is also important to reiterate that for the purpose of highlighting unifying trends across participants, differences associated with varying institutional contexts have been obscured. As such, there remains an open question for future research into how certain characteristics that may distinguish particular higher education contexts may influence these findings. For example, how might academic high achievers who attend large regional state schools where many may be majoring in teaching be socialized? Could it be that these high achievers receive fewer negative signals about teaching because they attend institutions where teaching is a common career path? Or could it be that they receive more negative signals about teaching in an effort to differentiate them from the "average student" in their institution?

It is also important to restate that I do not set out to causally link negative conceptions of teaching to high achievers' unwillingness to become teachers or to highlight that some socialization processes may be more or less likely to lead to high achievers choosing to become teachers. Indeed, this is why, aside from Ashley, I do not reveal in their vignettes that two other high achievers (Rory and Graham) chose to become teachers during the year following the interviews. Rather, my aim is to present the range of ways that study participants learned that teaching was an "inappropriate" career choice for high achievers like them. I look to future research to provide us with causal evidence that being exposed to negative conceptions of teaching leads to disinterest.

Coda

A few weeks after conducting the interviews, I ask a colleague, who is about to retire, what they think it will take for us to change many parents' perceptions that teaching is not an appropriate career for their academically high-achieving children. She looks me up and down, like a battle-worn veteran general looking at a young and uncertain officer. For over twenty years she has been a professor of education studies and the director of a highly regarded teacher preparation program at an elite college. We've spoken often about students who come into our offices and say, "Well, I'd love to be a teacher, but my parents don't want me to waste my [elite college] education." Her response is

always: “I go ballistic! ‘What could be more important? Let me talk to your parents.’”

She recounts a story from a Junior Parents Weekend event she spoke at a few years ago. “We were in the lecture theater and I had them tape a card under every seat. I said to the parents, ‘I want you to look under your seat. There’s a card. I want you to write down the name of an important teacher.’ Everybody does it in a heartbeat. A to Z, everyone that’s there, everyone’s got a great teacher. And they don’t just have the name, they have stories; they really want to tell you about them. They’re desperate to tell you about them.”

“Then I said, ‘Okay, so you’ve got this name of this person who was an important teacher to you. I’d like you to imagine that twenty years from now we do the same thing, and people pull up this card and they write down the name of your son or your daughter.’ The room was dead silent, and I didn’t say anything more. You can call it a guilt trip or whatever, but just how would you feel? You know me, I don’t take any prisoners. I just let it sit.”

Notes

1. To protect the confidentiality of the participants, I use pseudonyms and anonymize institutions and any other identifying features, such as club names and place names.
2. My use of *high achiever* or *high achieving* as shorthand to describe academic high achievers is for brevity rather than an assertion that any one quality like high GPA or SAT score or attendance at an elite academic undergraduate institution is a necessary and/or sufficient indicator of merit or achievement.

References

- Auguste, B., Kihn, P., & Miller, M. (2010). *Closing the talent gap: Attracting and retaining top-third graduates to careers in teaching: An international and market research-based perspective*. McKinsey. Retrieved from <https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/public-and-social-sector/our-insights/closing-the-teaching-talent-gap>
- Barber, M., & Mourshed, M. (2007). *How the world’s best performing school systems come out on top*. McKinsey. Retrieved from <https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/public-and-social-sector/our-insights/how-the-worlds-best-performing-school-systems-come-out-on-top>
- Battilana, J., Leca, B., & Boxenbaum, E. (2009). How actors change institutions: Towards a theory of institutional entrepreneurship. *Academy of Management Annals*, 3(1), 65–107. doi:10.1080/19416520903053598
- Binder, A. J., Davis, D. B., & Bloom, N. (2016). Career funneling: How elite students learn to define and desire “prestigious” jobs. *Sociology of Education*, 89(1), 20–39. doi:10.1177/0038040715610883
- Carter, K. (1993). The place of story in the study of teaching and teacher education. *Educational Researcher*, 22(1), 5–18. doi:10.3102/0013189X022001005
- Cohen, D. K. (2011). *Teaching and its predicaments*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Cowan, J., Goldhaber, D., Hayes, K., & Theobald, R. (2016). Missing elements in the discussion of teacher shortages. *Educational Researcher*, 45(8), 460–462. doi:10.3102/0013189X16679145

- D'Agostino, J. V., & Powers, S. J. (2009). Predicting teacher performance with test scores and grade point average: A meta-analysis. *American Educational Research Journal*, 46(1), 146–182. doi:10.3102/0002831208323280
- Darling-Hammond, L. (1984). *Beyond the commission reports: The coming crisis in teaching*. RAND Corporation. Retrieved from <https://www.rand.org/pubs/reports/R3177.html>
- Duncan, A. (2011). *Working toward “wow”: A vision for a new teaching profession*. Retrieved from <https://www.ed.gov/news/speeches/working-toward-wow-vision-new-teaching-profession>
- Etzioni, A. (1969). *The semi-professions and their organization: Teachers, nurses, social workers*. New York: Free Press.
- Farkas, S., Johnson, J., & Foleno, T. (2000). *A sense of calling: Who teaches and why*. Public Agenda. Retrieved from <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED443815.pdf>
- Featherstone, J. (1989). To make the spirit whole. *Harvard Educational Review*, 59(3), 367–378. doi:10.17763/haer.59.3.0392h53811473716
- Fenstermacher, G. D., & Richardson, V. (2005). On making determinations of quality in teaching. *Teachers College Record*, 107(1), 186–213. doi:10.1111/j.1467-9620.2005.00462.x
- Glaser, B. G., & Strauss, A. L. (1967). *The discovery of grounded theory: Strategies for qualitative research*. Chicago: Aldine.
- Goldring, R., Taie, S., & Riddles, M. (2014). *Teacher attrition and mobility: Results from the 2012–13 teacher follow-up survey* (NCES 2014-077). National Center for Education Statistics. Retrieved from <https://nces.ed.gov/pubsearch/pubsinfo.asp?pubid=2014077>
- Gombrich, E. H. (1969). *Art and illusion: A study in the psychology of pictorial representation* (2nd ed.). Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- Hanushek, E. A., Piopiunik, M., & Wiederhold, S. (2019). The value of smarter teachers: International evidence on teacher cognitive skills and student performance. *Journal of Human Resources*, 54(4), 857–899. doi:10.3368/jhr.54.4.0317.8619r1
- Henry, G. T., Bastian, K. C., & Smith, A. A. (2012). Scholarships to recruit the “best and brightest” into teaching: Who is recruited, where do they teach, how effective are they, and how long do they stay? *Educational Researcher*, 41(3), 83–92. doi:10.3102/0013189X12437202
- Hiler, T., & Erickson, L. (2014). *Teaching: The next generation. Report on education from Third Way*. Retrieved from <http://www.thirdway.org/report/teaching-the-next-generation/>
- Ho, K. (2009). *Liquidated: An ethnography of Wall Street*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
- Holmes Group. (1986). *Tomorrow's teachers*. Retrieved from <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED270454>
- Hoyle, E. (2001). Teaching: Prestige, status and esteem. *Educational Management & Administration*, 29(2), 139–152. doi:10.1177/0263211x010292001
- Karabel, J. (2005). *The chosen: The hidden history of admission and exclusion at Harvard, Yale, and Princeton*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.
- Kelchtermans, G., & Vandenbergh, R. (1994). Teachers' professional development: A biographical perspective. *Journal of Curriculum Studies*, 26(1), 45–62. doi:10.1080/0022027940260103
- Kennedy, M. M. (2006). *Inside teaching: How classroom life undermines reform*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Labaree, D. (2004). *The trouble with ed schools*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Lawrence, T., Suddaby, R., & Leca, B. (2011). Institutional work: Refocusing institutional studies of organization. *Journal of Management Inquiry*, 20(1), 52–58. doi:10.1177/10.56492610387222

- Lawrence-Lightfoot, S. (2000). *Respect: An exploration*. Cambridge, MA: Perseus Books.
- Lawrence-Lightfoot, S., & Davis, J. H. (1997). *The art and science of portraiture*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass.
- Liu, E., Johnson, S. M., & Peske, H. G. (2004). New teachers and the Massachusetts signing bonus: The limits of inducements. *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*, 26(3), 217–236. doi:10.3102/01623737026003217
- Lortie, D. (1975). *Schoolteacher: A sociological study*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Miles, M. B., & Huberman, A. M. (1994). *Qualitative data analysis: An expanded sourcebook* (2nd ed.). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage.
- Patton, M. Q. (1990). *Qualitative evaluation and research methods* (2nd ed.). Newbury Park, CA: Sage.
- Preissle, J., & LeCompte, M. D. (1984). *Ethnography and qualitative design in educational research*. New York: Academic Press.
- Reback, R. (2006). Entry costs and the supply of public school teachers. *Education Finance and Policy*, 1(2), 247–265. doi:10.1162/edfp.2006.1.2.247
- Rivera, L. (2015). *Pedigree: Elite reproduction in hiring*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
- Rowsey, R. E., & Ley, T. C. (1986). Perceptions of teachers' salaries and non-salary benefits. *Journal of Teacher Education*, 37(2), 42–45. doi:10.1177/002248718603700208
- Schjeldahl, P. (2019, September 23). Beheld. *The New Yorker*. Retrieved from <https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2019/09/23/the-amy-sherald-effect>
- Schneider, B., & Stevenson, D. (1999). *The ambitious generation: America's teenagers, motivated but directionless*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Smith, T. W., Davern, M., Freese, J., & Morgan, S. L. (2019). Appendix F. In *General social surveys, 1972–2018: Cumulative codebook* (No. 25). National Data Program for the Social Sciences Series. National Opinion Research Center. Retrieved from https://gss.norc.umd.edu/documents/codebook/gss_codebook.pdf
- Sutcher, L., Darling-Hammond, L., & Carver-Thomas, D. (2016). *A coming crisis in teaching? Teacher supply, demand, and shortages in the US*. Learning Policy Institute. Retrieved from <https://learningpolicyinstitute.org/product/coming-crisis-teaching>
- Tripp, D. (1994). Teachers' lives, critical incidents, and professional practice. *International Journal of Qualitative Studies in Education*, 7(1), 65–76. doi:10.1080/0951839940070105
- Warikoo, N. K. (2016). *The diversity bargain: And other dilemmas of race, admissions, and meritocracy at elite universities*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Weingarten, R. (2019). *The freedom to teach*. National Press Club. Retrieved from <https://www.aft.org/freedomtototeach>

Acknowledgments

I am grateful to Irene Liefshitz, Jeremy Murphy, Julia Jeffries, Emily Qazilbash, Laura Frustaci, Sophie Bauder, Jaden Deal, and seminar participants at the Harvard Graduate School of Education and Brown University. All errors and omissions are my own.

This article has been reprinted with permission of the *Harvard Educational Review* (ISSN 0017-8055) for personal use only. Posting on a public website or on a listserv is not allowed. Any other use, print or electronic, will require written permission from the *Review*. You may subscribe to *HER* at www.harvardeducationalreview.org. *HER* is published quarterly by the Harvard Education Publishing Group, 8 Story Street, Cambridge, MA 02138, tel. 617-495-3432. Copyright © by the President and Fellows of Harvard College. All rights reserved.